

## Democrats are narrow favorites to win Senate

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### 【メール原文】

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Putin's invite to G20 summit undermines stability in transatlantic relations

Democrats are narrow favorites to win Senate. We have updated our Senate call to a narrow Democratic majority (55% odds, up from 45%). Democratic polling leads have endured in key races, and the Democratic lead in the generic congressional ballot has continued to grow as campaign season stretched on.

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This makes a unified Democratic Congress our basecase (55% odds), as if Democrats win the Senate they will nearly certainly win the House as well. A split Congress (Democratic House, Republican Senate) sits at 30% odds, while we give 15% odds to a unified Republican Congress.

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Macro developments and polling in key races support a slight Democratic advantage. High gas prices are pulling down Republican candidates, and Democrats have consistently led in polls in Texas, Ohio, and Alaska in recent weeks.

\*

The race is still close, though; small polling errors in a few states would be enough for Republicans to hold on, while a combination of massive October spending and Republican leaners coming home could carry Republicans over the line.

\*

A unified Democratic Congress matters most for nominations. A split Congress was already going to paralyze the legislative agenda; Democratic control of the Senate would make it difficult, though not impossible, for the administration to confirm nominees to executive and judicial posts, and would force it to rely on acting and deputy secretaries to fill vacancies.

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For more, please see [Democrats are now narrow Senate favorites](#) , 24 September 2026.

Diesel export restrictions before mid-October now appear likely. We are updating our call to 65% odds of partial diesel export restrictions before October 15; we previously viewed them as only likely if prices remained raised past that date. Spiking diesel costs in US agricultural states has created significant backlash among President Donald Trump's base, with near-term price pressure outweighing concerns that restrictions would have limited impact.

\*

The US is likely to use restrictions to gradually lower exports from their current highs near 1.4 million bpd to pre-war levels of around 1 million bpd. The administration has several options to impose restrictions, with an export license requirement via the Bureau of Industry and Security (BIS) appearing most likely as of now. In practice, this would allow the administration to selectively halt diesel exports to bring down overall export volumes, and then adjust that level via approval or denial of export licenses as needed moving forward. Other options such as use of emergency authorities are possible. The administration may also frame export denials as targeted at specific nations, though these restrictions would be difficult to enforce in practice and would be primarily a messaging exercise.

\*

Price relief in the US would be short-term, with diesel surpluses putting downward pressure on prices in the Gulf Coast and Midwest while the East and West Coasts see little, if any, relief. Downward movement in prices would be temporary, as refiners would likely reduce operations as inventories fill up, putting upward pressure on the prices of other refined products, including gasoline.

\*

Our 35% odds against export restrictions would increase if prices decrease towards diesel's 2022 high (\$5.81); Secretaries Scott Bessent or Chris Wright reverse their hesitant support for restrictions; or lobbying by impacted groups, namely oil refiners, sways the opinion of key cabinet members. It also remains possible Trump can talk down market prices through the simple threat of export restrictions.

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For more, please see US likely to restrict diesel exports , 23 September 2026.

Putin's invite to G20 summit undermines stability in transatlantic relations. Secretary of State Marco Rubio announced yesterday that Russian leader Vladimir Putin had been invited to attend the upcoming G20 summit in Miami. The decision follows on Russia's invitation to the G20 Finance Ministerial in August.

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These moves are primarily aimed at a domestic audience to strengthen Trump's dealmaker persona and to signal to Americans that he is working to broker peace in Ukraine. From that perspective, this announcement aligns with our view that Trump's bombastic nature will continue to ramp up anxiety in European capitals (see: Transatlantic relations inch back from the precipice , 9 September 2026).

\*

Inviting Putin is a reminder that while transatlantic relations have stabilized they remain at a low ebb, and there will be constant points of irritation between the US and EU capitals for the remainder of the Trump term. Trump's willingness to engage face-to-face with Putin, without any concessions vis-à-vis Ukraine, will be one of those.

\*

As Russia accelerates subthreshold, grey-zone attacks in Europe – through drone incursions and cyber interference – US-NATO alignment will be a key factor in constraining future Russian aggression and

avoiding larger, conventional military engagements. For more, see Hot war with West remains unlikely as Russia escalates hybrid activity , 14 September 2026.

#### Quote of the Day

"The juxtaposition is hard to miss. The Chinese are holding some of our most sensitive technology and we are rolling out the red carpet for their president." - Sen. Elissa Slotkin (D-MI) speaking to Bloomberg about reporting that China acquired a missing shipment of F-35 parts bound for the US. The White House has faced bipartisan criticism for planning such a lavish welcome for Xi Jinping, and several lawmakers recently gave speeches urging Trump to take a hard line on human rights, economic, and military issues. With Trump's priority in this summit being maintaining a good relationship with Xi, it is unlikely he will raise contentious topics.

#### On the Radar

18-28 September: High-Level Week at UN General Assembly

24 September: Trump-Xi summit

2 October: Last day Senate is in session before midterms

3 November: National midterm elections

10 November: US-China tariff truce expires

18-19 November: APEC leaders meeting in China

11 December: Government funding runs out

14-15 December: G20 summit in Florida

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